

India's Demographic Transition

Fertility, mortality, age structure and labour force through the decades that reshaped India.

5 CHAPTERS	25 INDICATORS	11 WITH STATE DATA	1951–2036 PERIOD COVERED
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Generated 21 Aug 2026 · assembled from 21 sources

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report assembles 25 indicators across 5 chapters, drawn from 21 sources and covering 1951–2036.

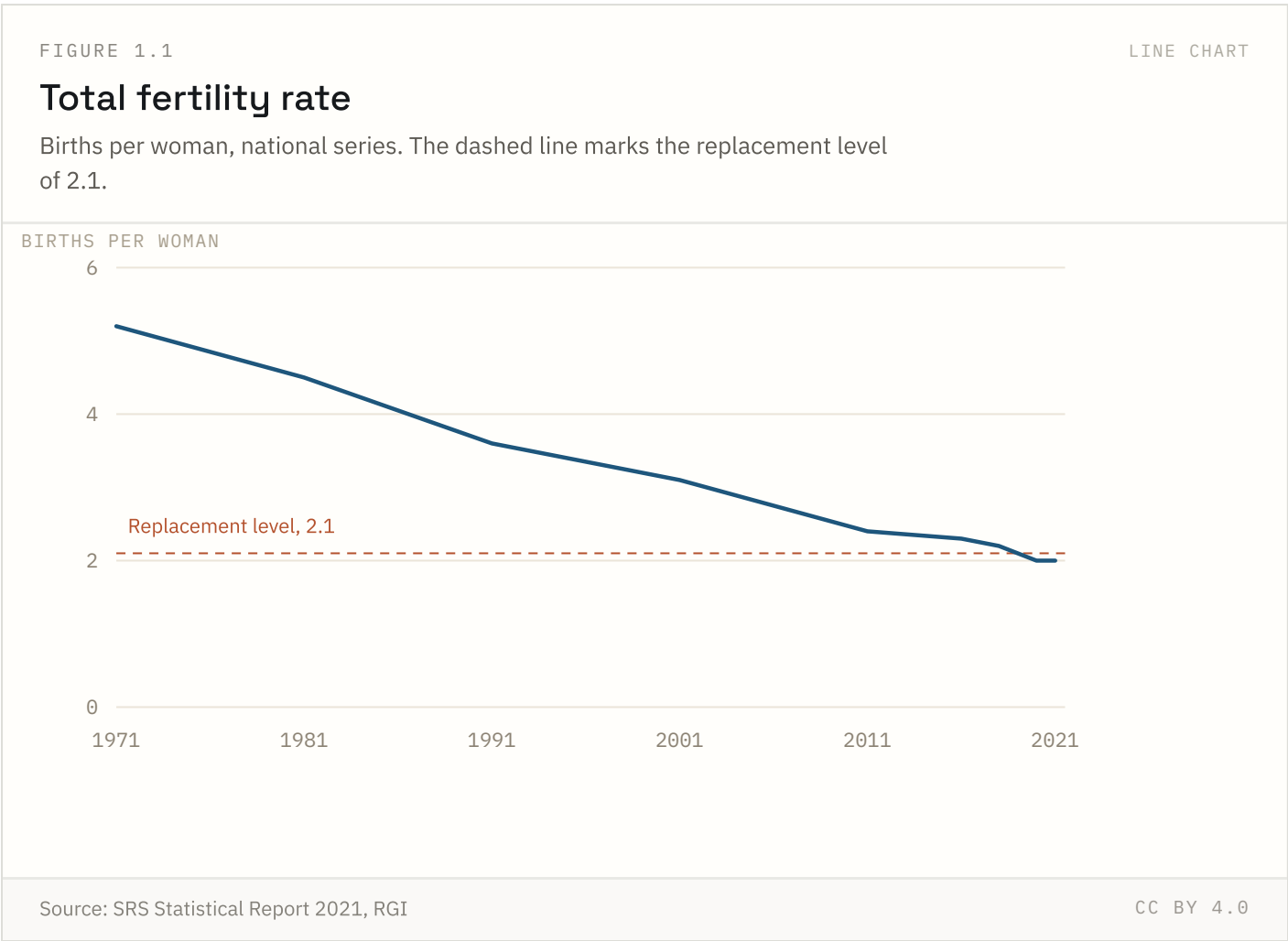
Of those indicators, 11 carry state-level detail and can be mapped across India's states. The remaining 14 are published at national level only by their source, and are shown here as national series without a sub-national breakdown.

Coverage limits. This report contains no district- or city-level figures. Comparable district data is not currently integrated into India Insight Lab, and no value here has been estimated, interpolated or carried down from a higher geography to fill that gap. Where a number is absent, it is absent.

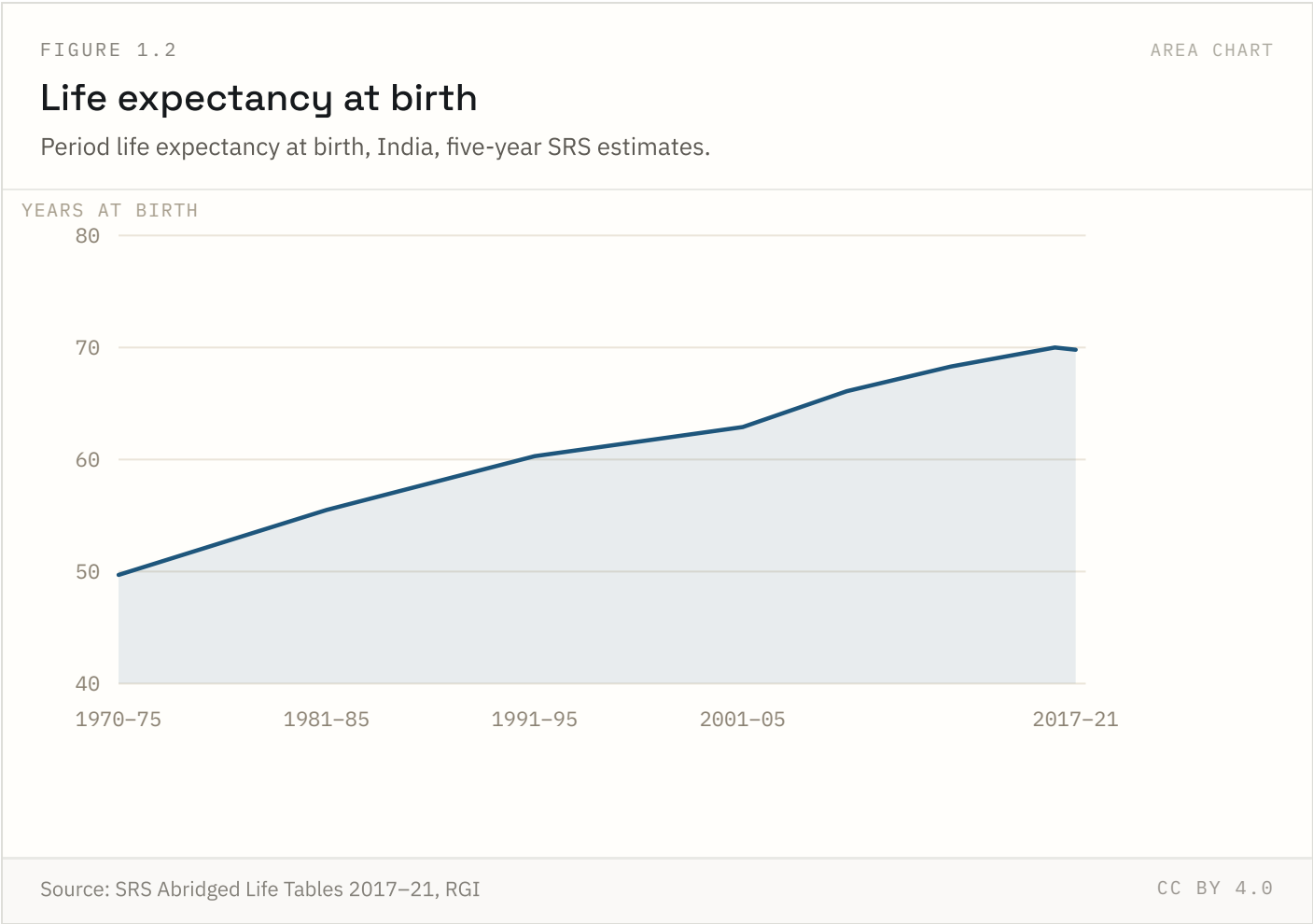
Population & demography

4 of 10 indicators in this chapter carry state-level detail; the rest are published at national level only.

FIGURE 1.1 NATIONAL + STATE



The total fertility rate is the number of children a woman would bear if she experienced current age-specific fertility rates throughout her reproductive life. We splice decennial Census-based estimates to 1991 with the annual Sample Registration System thereafter; NFHS rounds are shown where they differ by more than 0.1.



Period life expectancy at birth assumes a newborn experiences current mortality rates at every age for life. It is not a forecast of any individual cohort. The 2021 fall is real and reflects pandemic excess mortality; estimates of its size still vary across sources by several years.



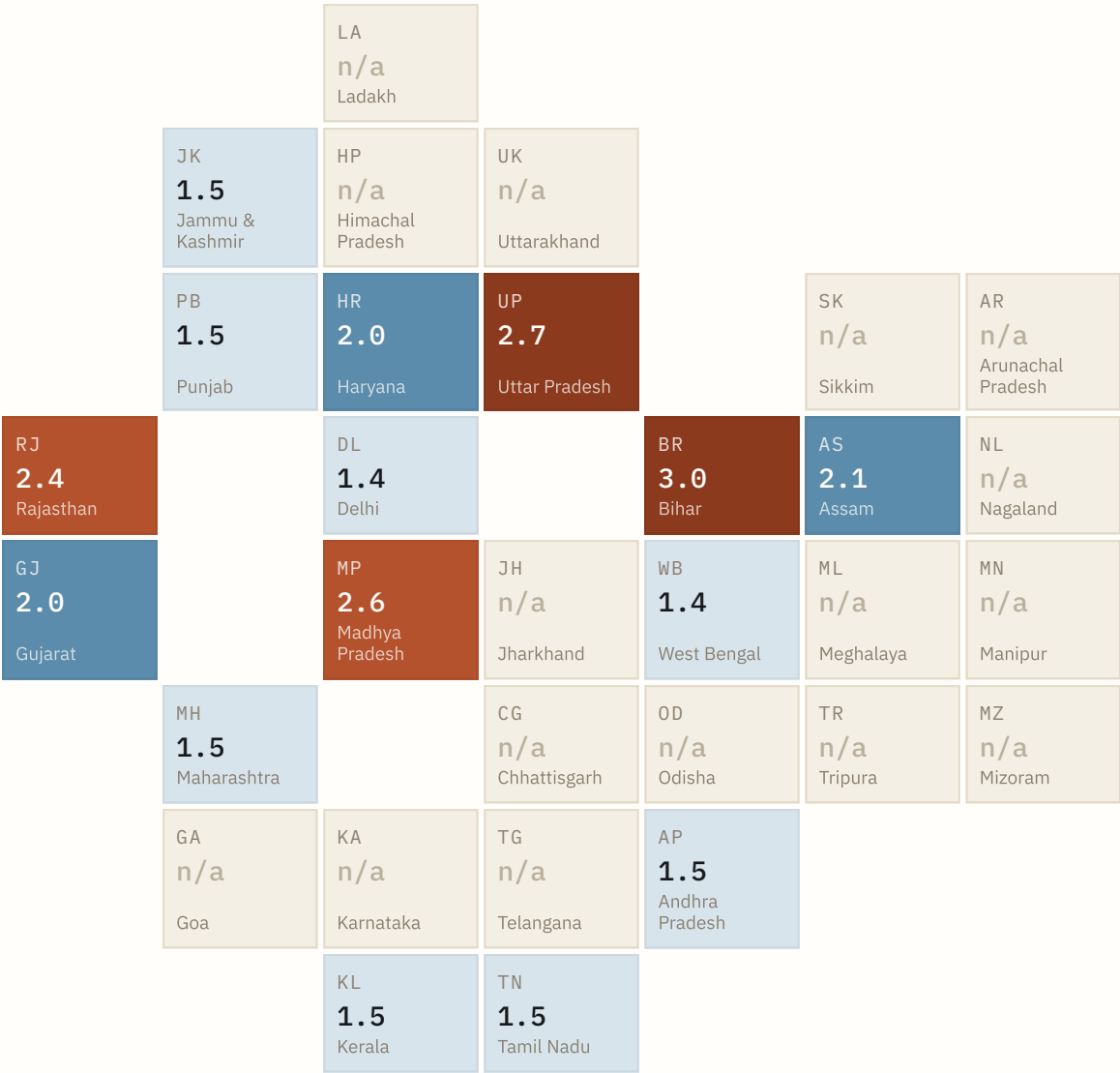
City-proper population excludes adjoining outgrowths and satellite towns, so it understates real metropolitan size — Delhi's urban agglomeration (16.3 million) is roughly 48% larger than its city-proper figure. We use city-proper because it is the more consistently defined boundary across cities.

FIGURE 1.4

TILE MAP

Fertility rate — tile map

One equal-area tile per State and UT, positioned to approximate relative geography.



≤ 1.5 1.6 – 1.9 2.0 – 2.2 2.3 – 2.6 ≥ 2.7

Schematic tile map: one tile per State / UT, positioned to approximate relative geography. Tiles are equal-area, so no state is visually over-weighted by land mass.

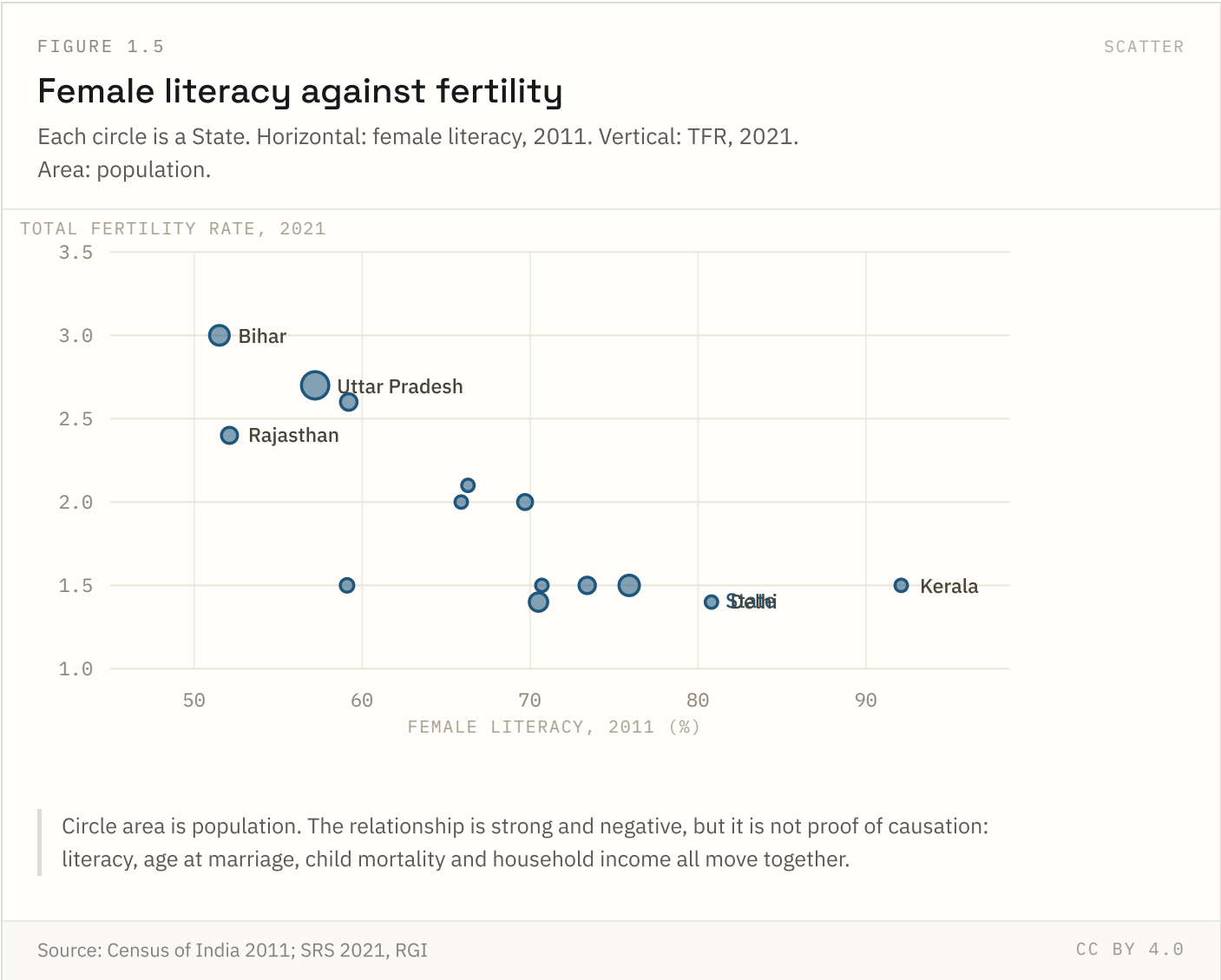
Source: SRS Statistical Report 2021, RGI

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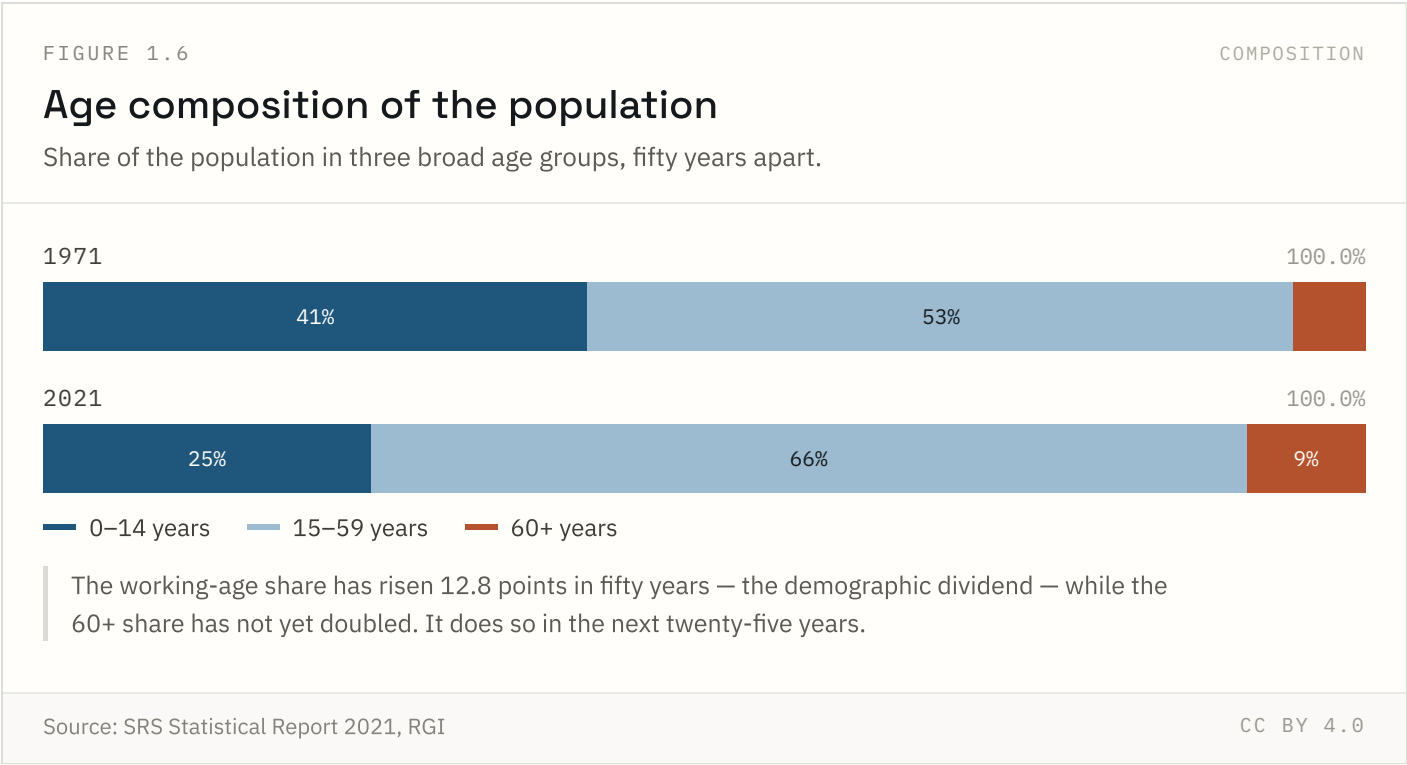
A tile map removes the visual bias of land area: Rajasthan does not shout louder than Kerala. Tiles marked n/a are States and UTs for which the SRS 2021 report does not publish a separate TFR estimate.

Source: SRS Statistical Report 2021, RGI Coverage: 2021 Updated: 18 Jul 2026

FIGURE 1.5 NATIONAL + STATE

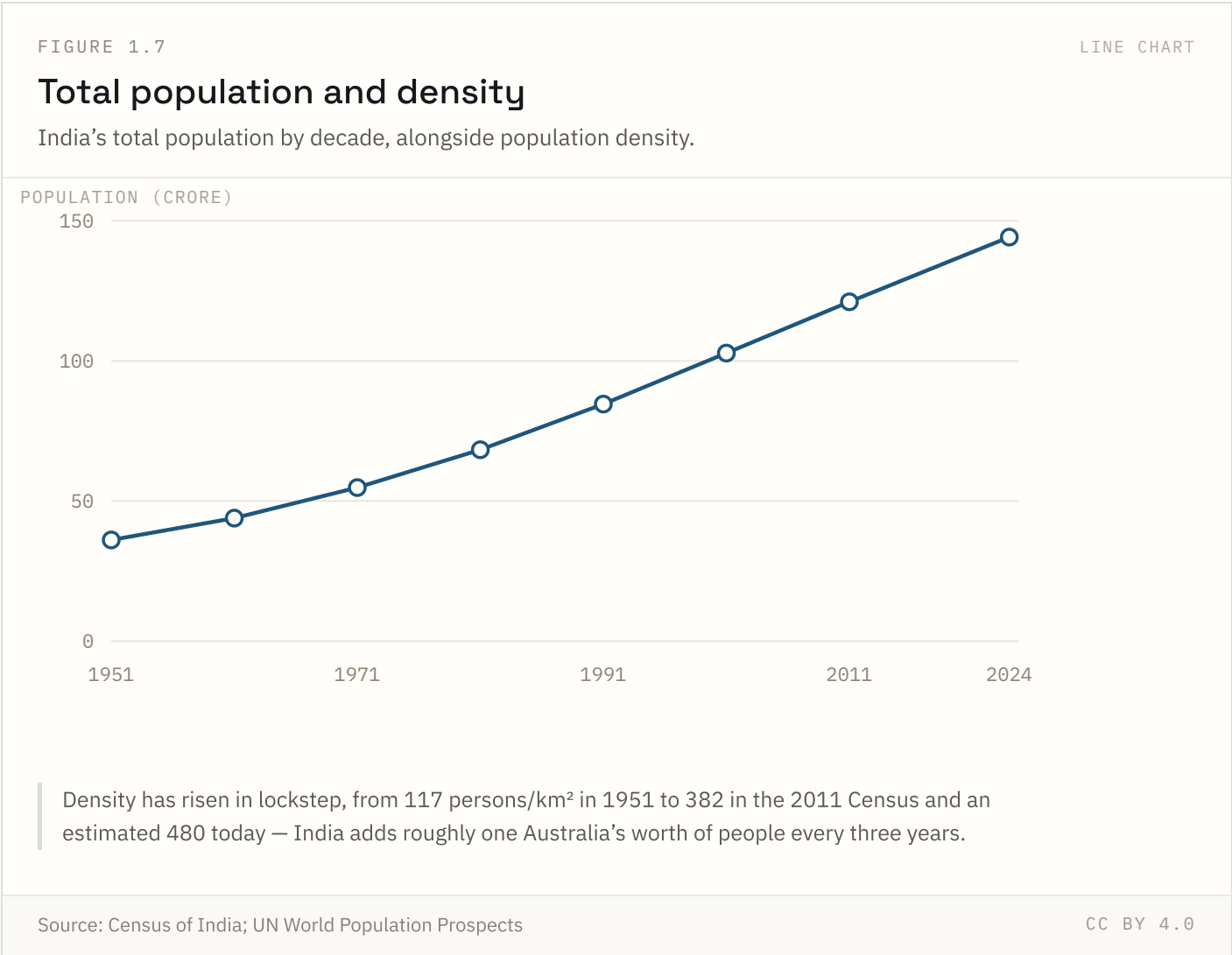


The negative relationship is strong across States, but it is not evidence of causation on its own — literacy, age at marriage, child mortality and household income all move together. Read it as a description of the fertility map, not a mechanism.



The 0–14 share fell from 41.2% to 24.8% between 1971 and 2021 while the working-age share rose to 66.2%. That gap is the demographic dividend; it closes as the 60+ share, now 9.0%, roughly doubles by 2050.

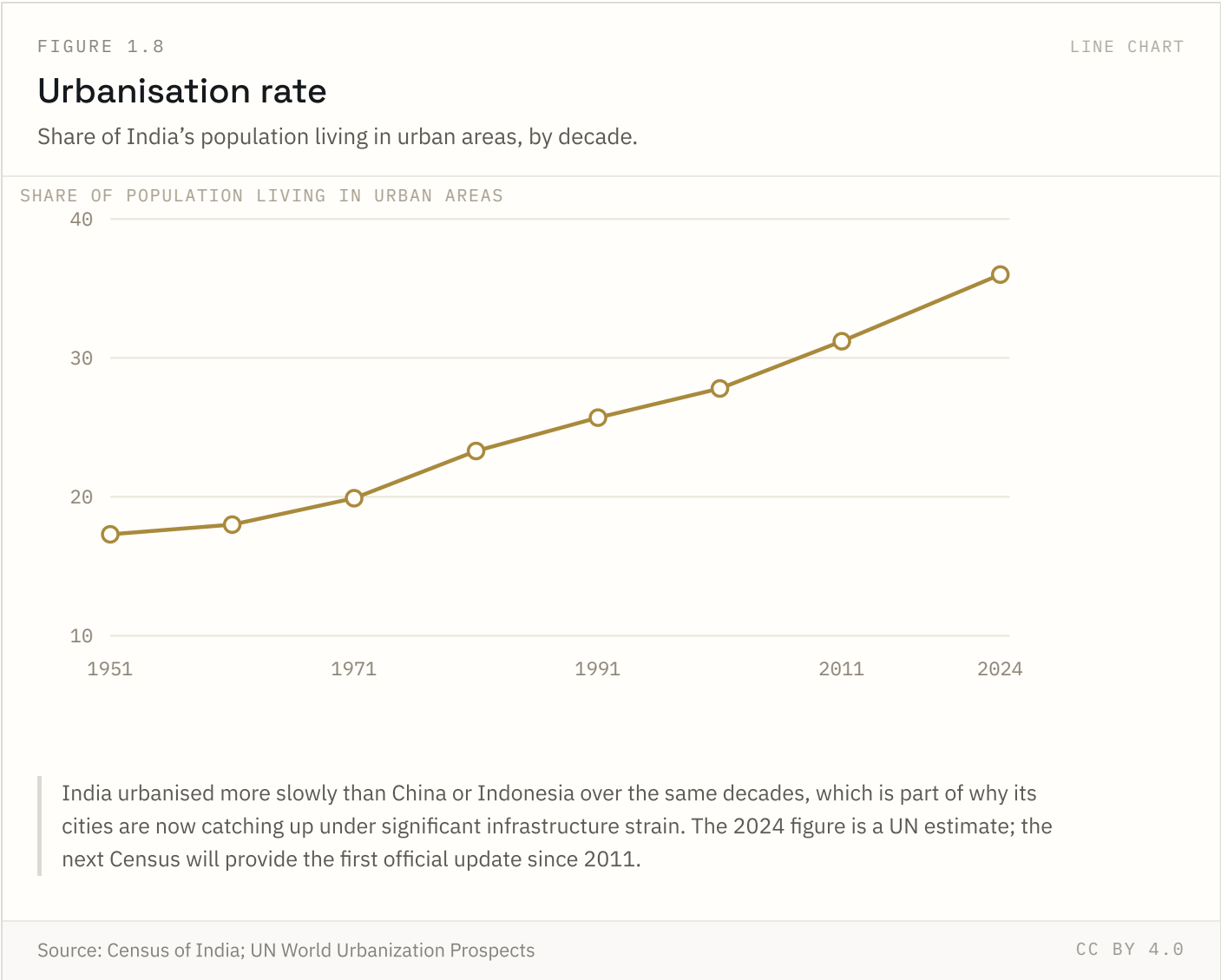
FIGURE 1.7 NATIONAL ONLY



India crossed 1 billion people around 2000 and an estimated 1.44 billion by 2024, having overtaken China as the world's most populous country in 2023. Density figures assume a fixed land area, so they track population growth almost exactly.

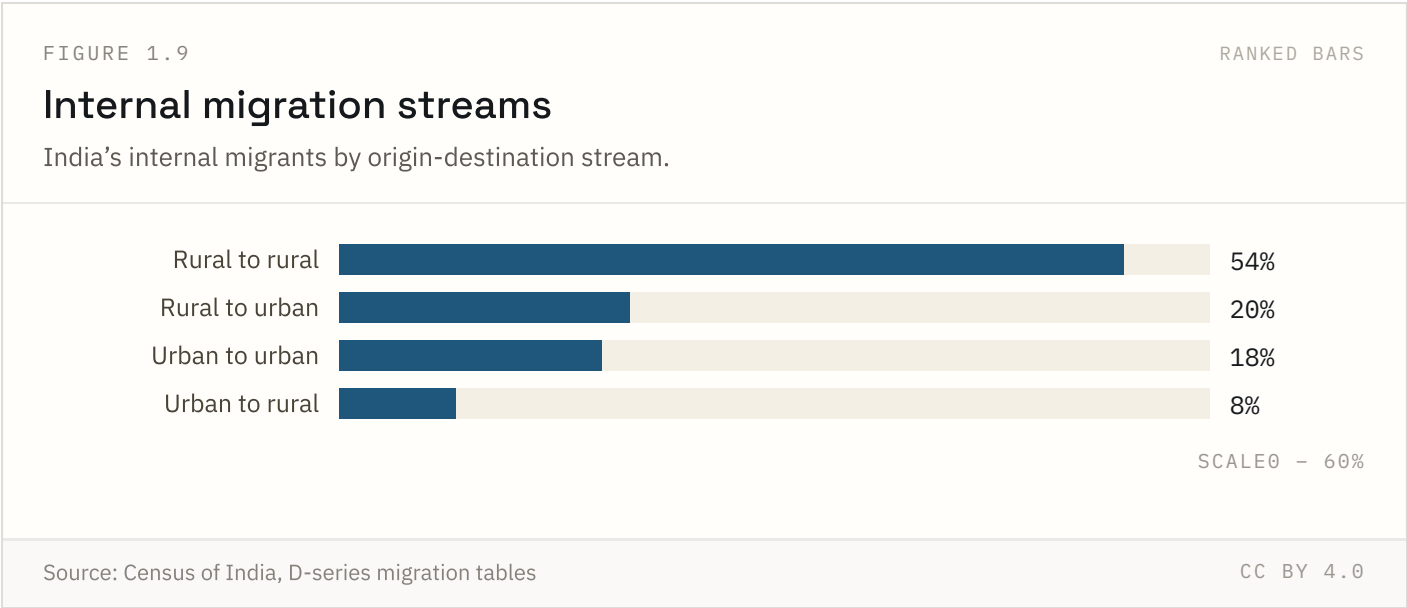
Source: Census of India; UN World Population Prospects Coverage: 1951–2024 Updated: 18 Aug 2026

FIGURE 1.8 NATIONAL ONLY



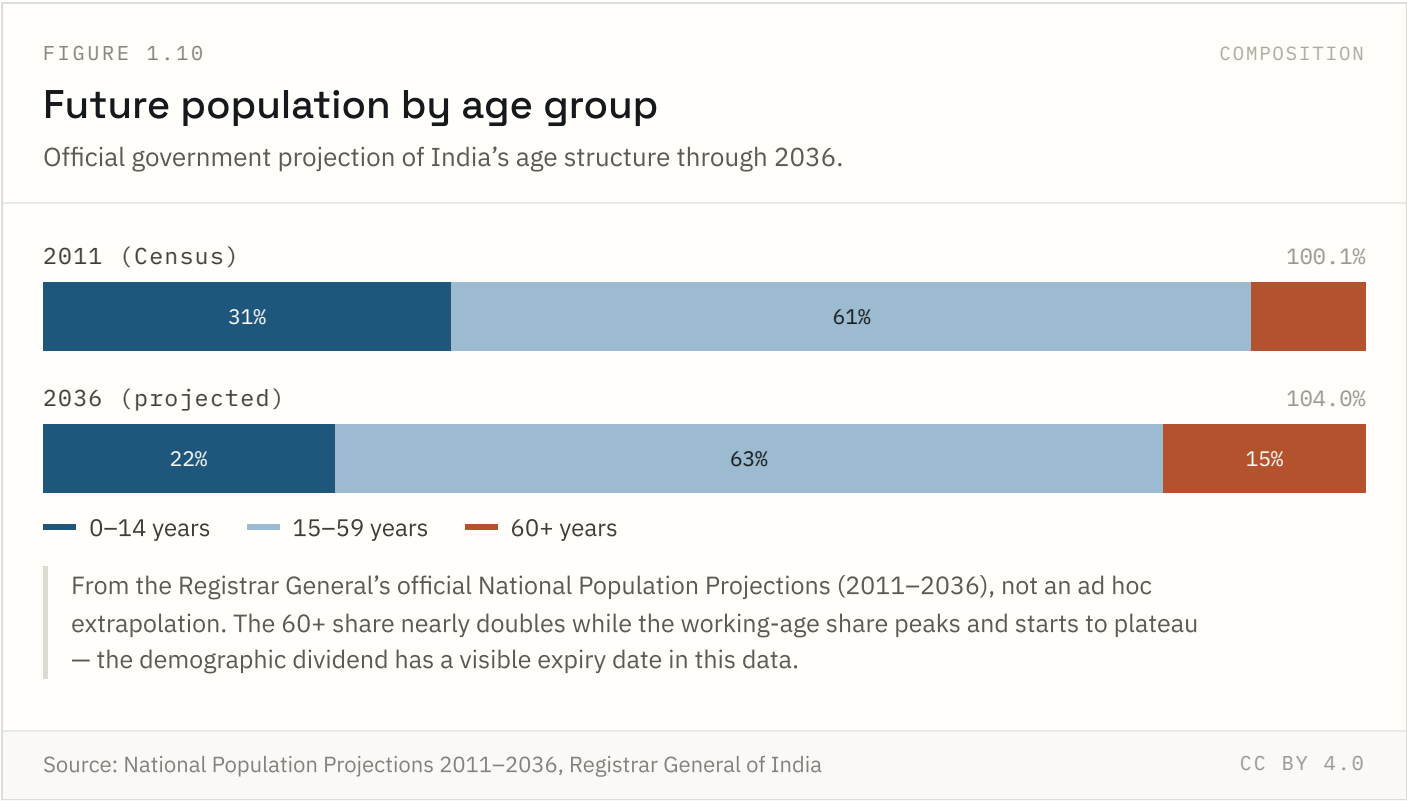
India’s urbanisation has been notably gradual compared to East Asian peers — a mixed blessing that avoided some of the informal-settlement crises seen elsewhere, but also means the next wave of urban growth, now underway, is arriving on infrastructure built for a smaller urban population.

FIGURE 1.9 NATIONAL ONLY



Rural-to-rural migration, mostly marriage-related moves by women, is the largest stream by volume — rural-to-urban labour migration, the stream most associated with India’s growth story, is actually the second largest, not the biggest.

Source: Census of India, D-series migration tables Coverage: 2011 Updated: 18 Aug 2026



This is RGI's own published projection, not an extrapolation built for this site. It shows the demographic dividend has a visible expiry date: the working-age share is projected to plateau around the mid-2030s as the 60+ share nearly doubles from its 2011 level.

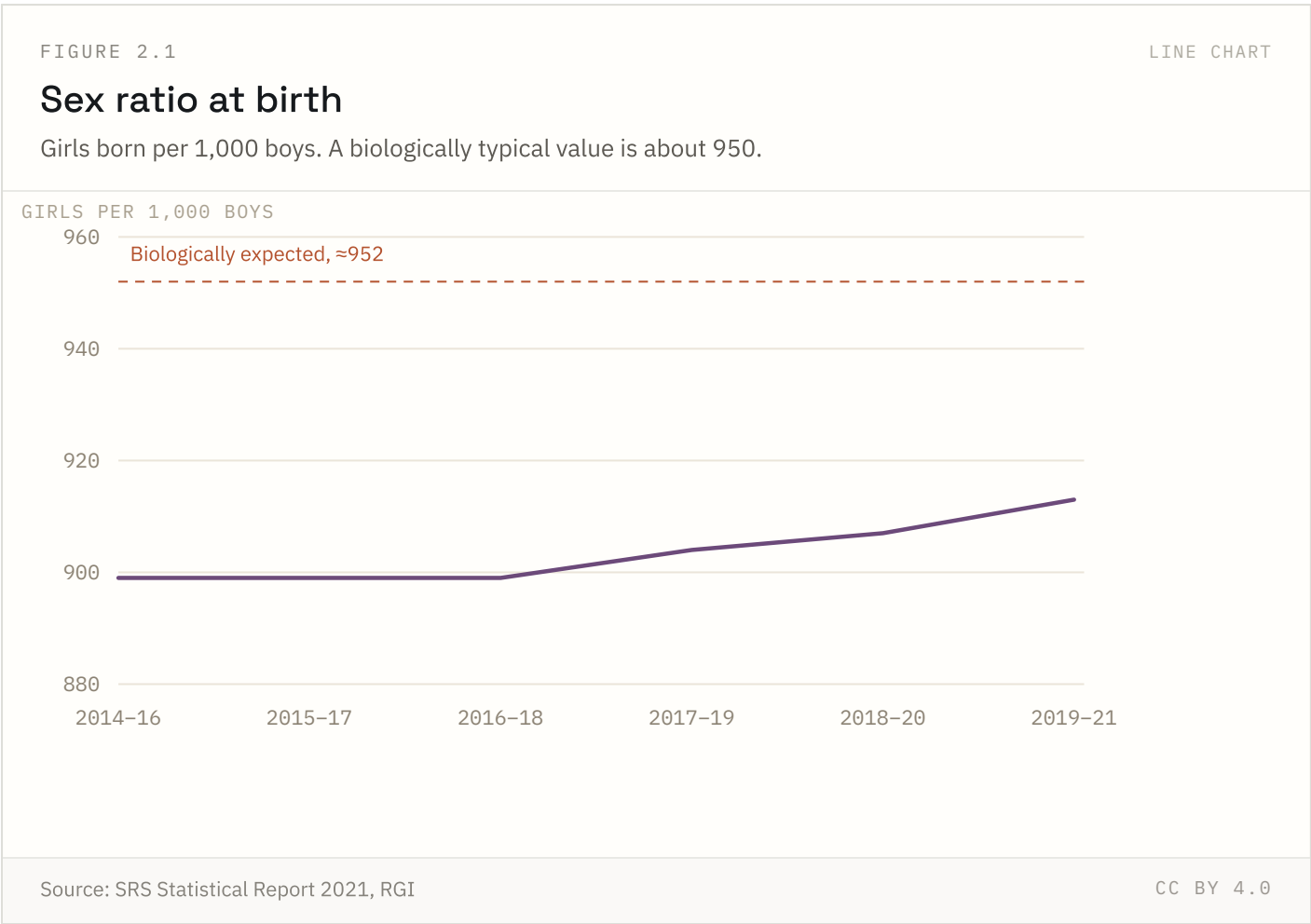
Source: National Population Projections 2011–2036, Registrar General of India

Coverage: 2011 to 2036 (projected) Updated: 18 Aug 2026

Gender

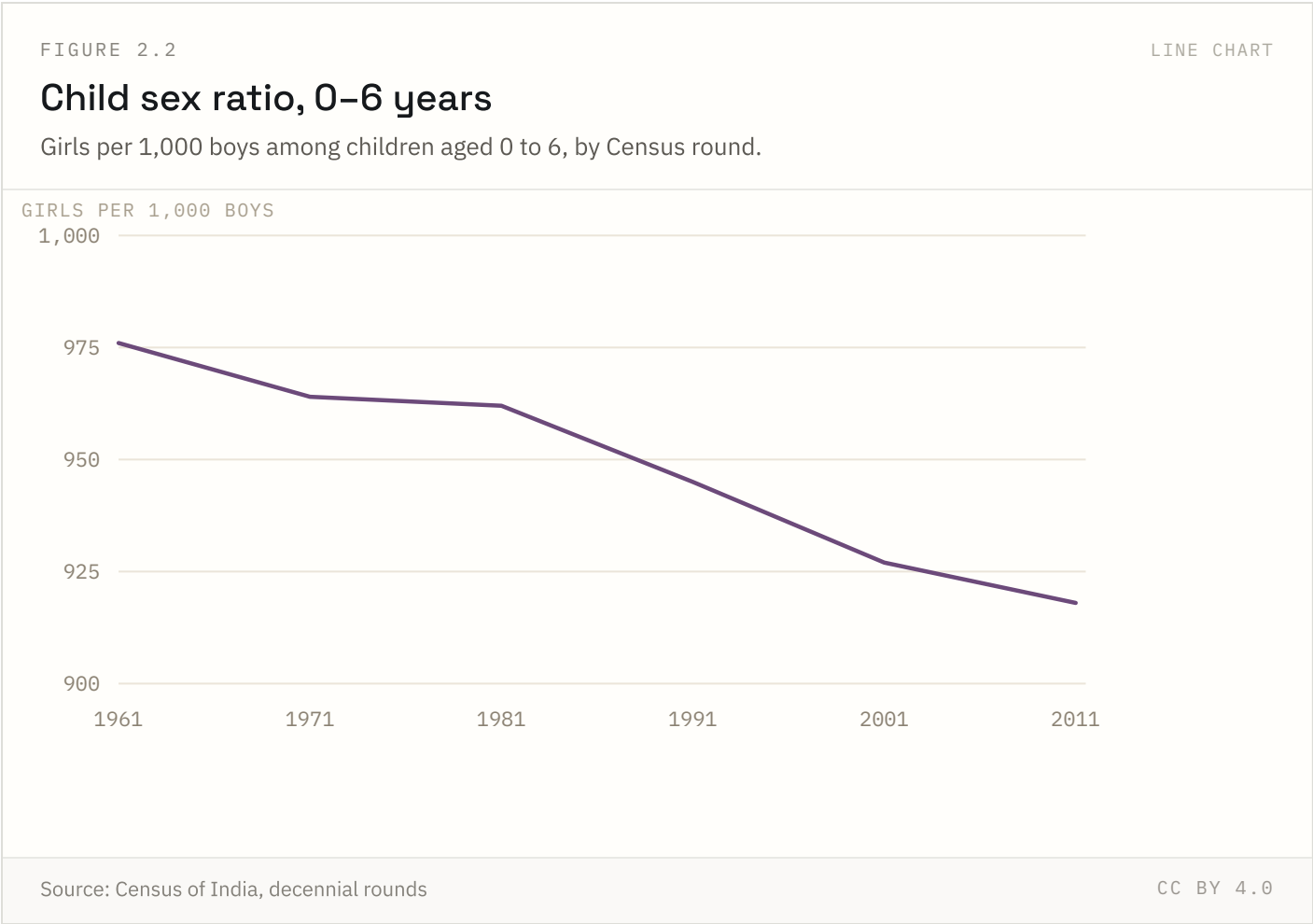
2 of 4 indicators in this chapter carry state-level detail; the rest are published at national level only.

FIGURE 2.1 NATIONAL + STATE



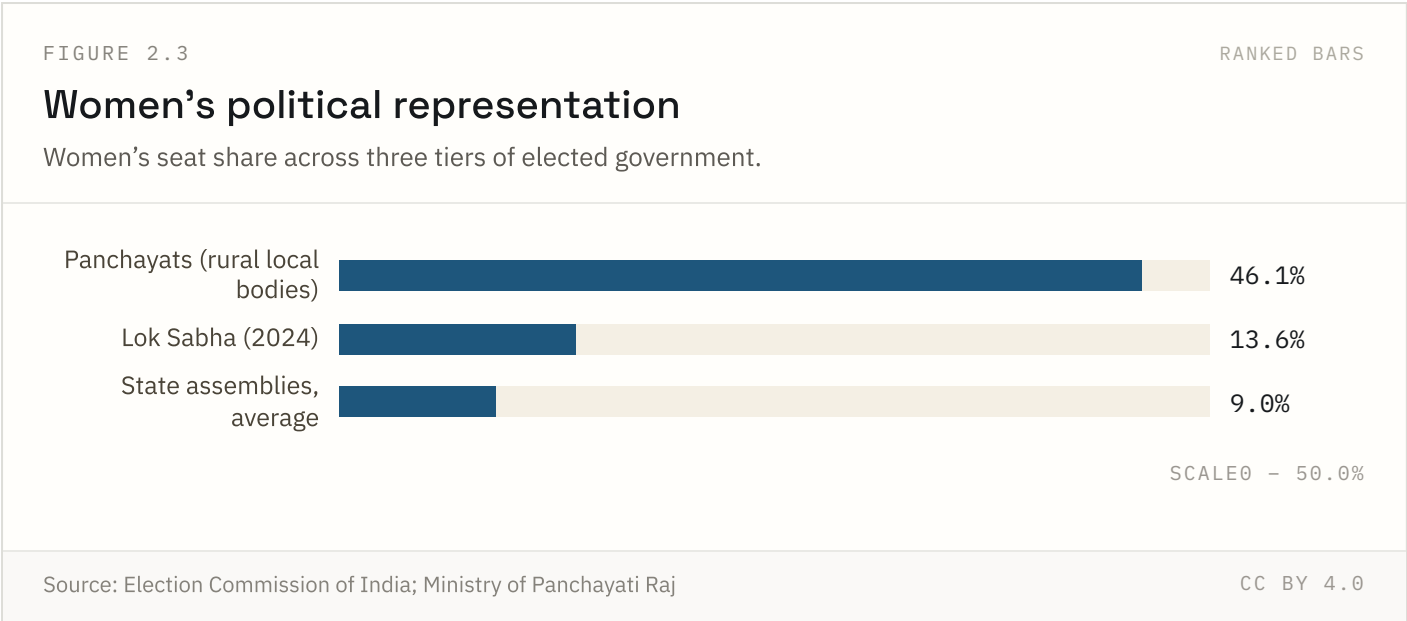
The ratio fell through the 1990s as ultrasound diagnosis spread, bottomed around 2011, and has partially recovered. Recovery is concentrated in Punjab, Haryana and Himachal Pradesh — the states where the deficit was worst.

Source: SRS Statistical Report 2021, RGI Coverage: 1991-2023 Updated: 21 Jul 2026



The child sex ratio fell in every round from 1961 to 2011, most sharply in the 1990s as ultrasound diagnosis spread. Unlike the sex ratio at birth, it also absorbs excess female mortality in early childhood.

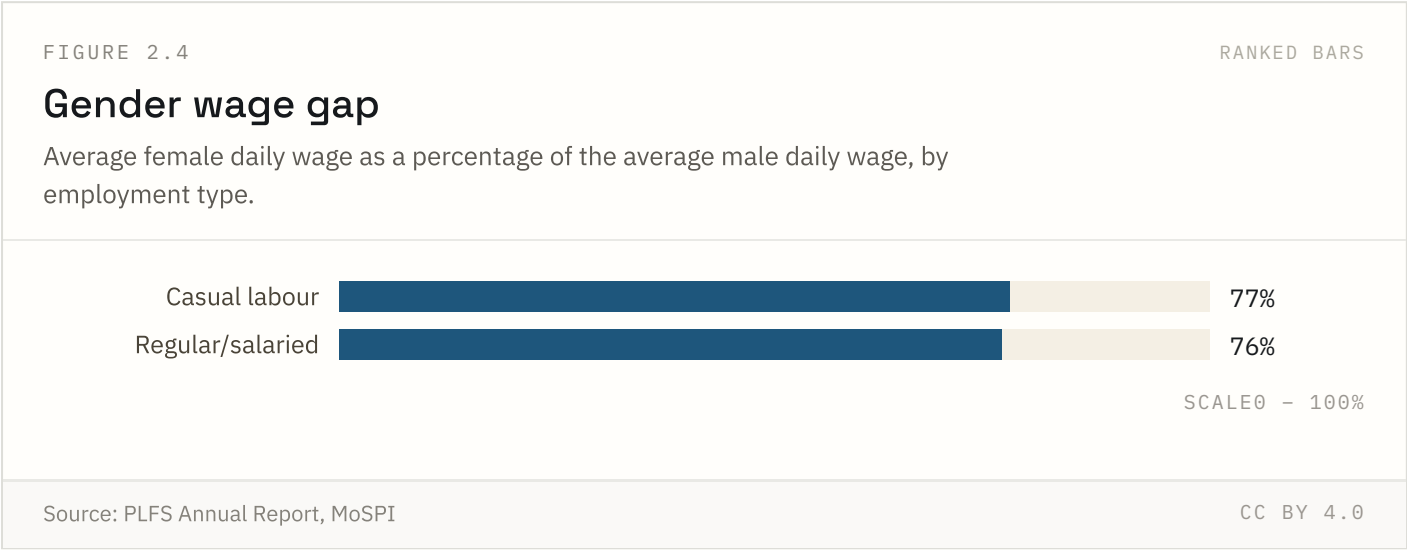
FIGURE 2.3 NATIONAL ONLY



Constitutional reservation (33–50% depending on state) drives the far higher Panchayat figure; no equivalent reservation exists yet for the Lok Sabha or most state assemblies, though a Women’s Reservation Act passed in 2023 is due to apply from the next delimitation.

Source: Election Commission of India; Ministry of Panchayati Raj Coverage: 2024 Updated: 18 Aug 2026

FIGURE 2.4 NATIONAL ONLY



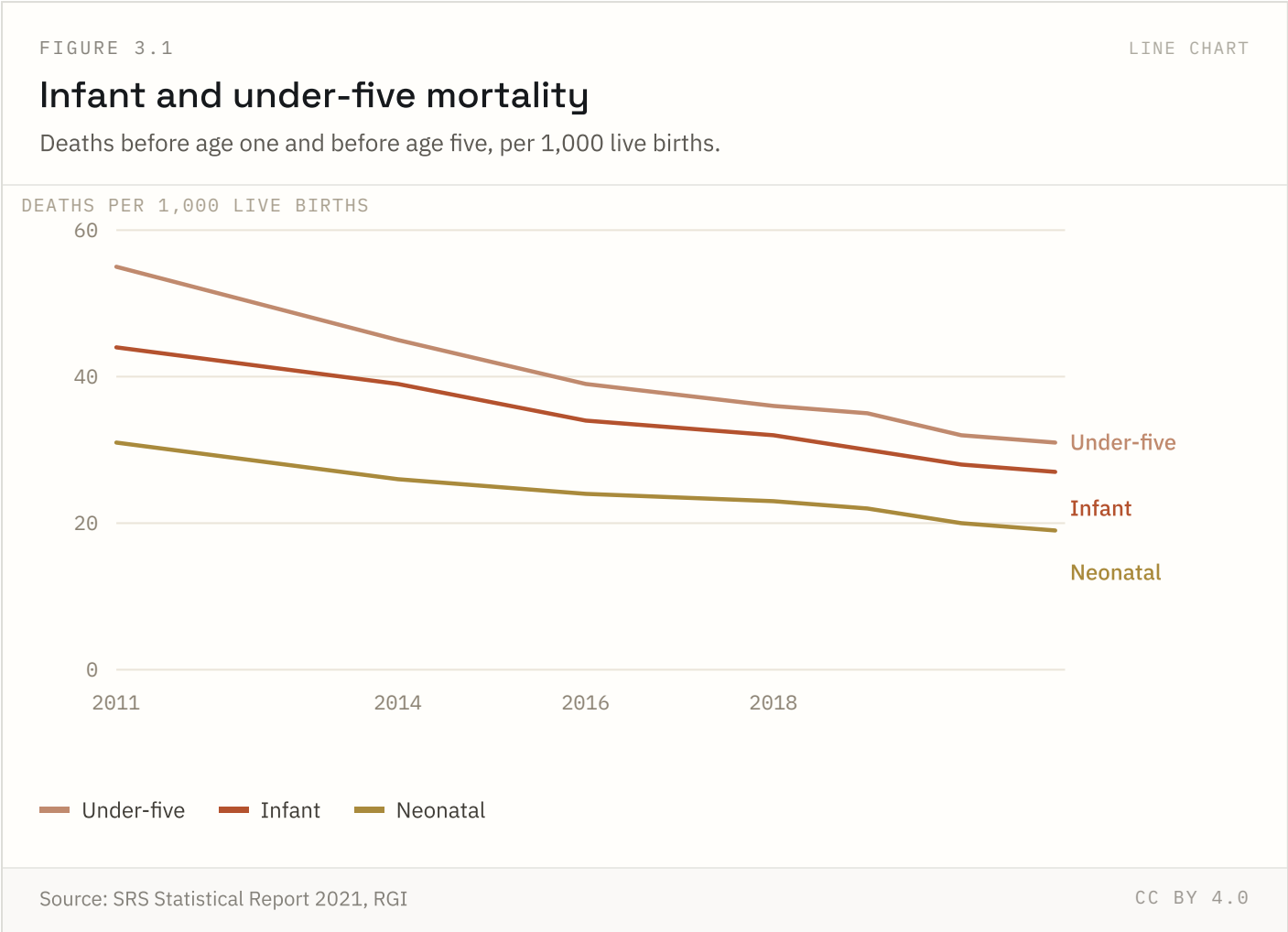
The gap has narrowed slowly over the past decade but persists across both casual and regular/salaried work, even after accounting for differences in sector and hours — unexplained gaps of this kind are consistent with occupational segregation and direct wage discrimination.

Source: PLFS Annual Report, MoSPI Coverage: 2023–24 Updated: 18 Aug 2026

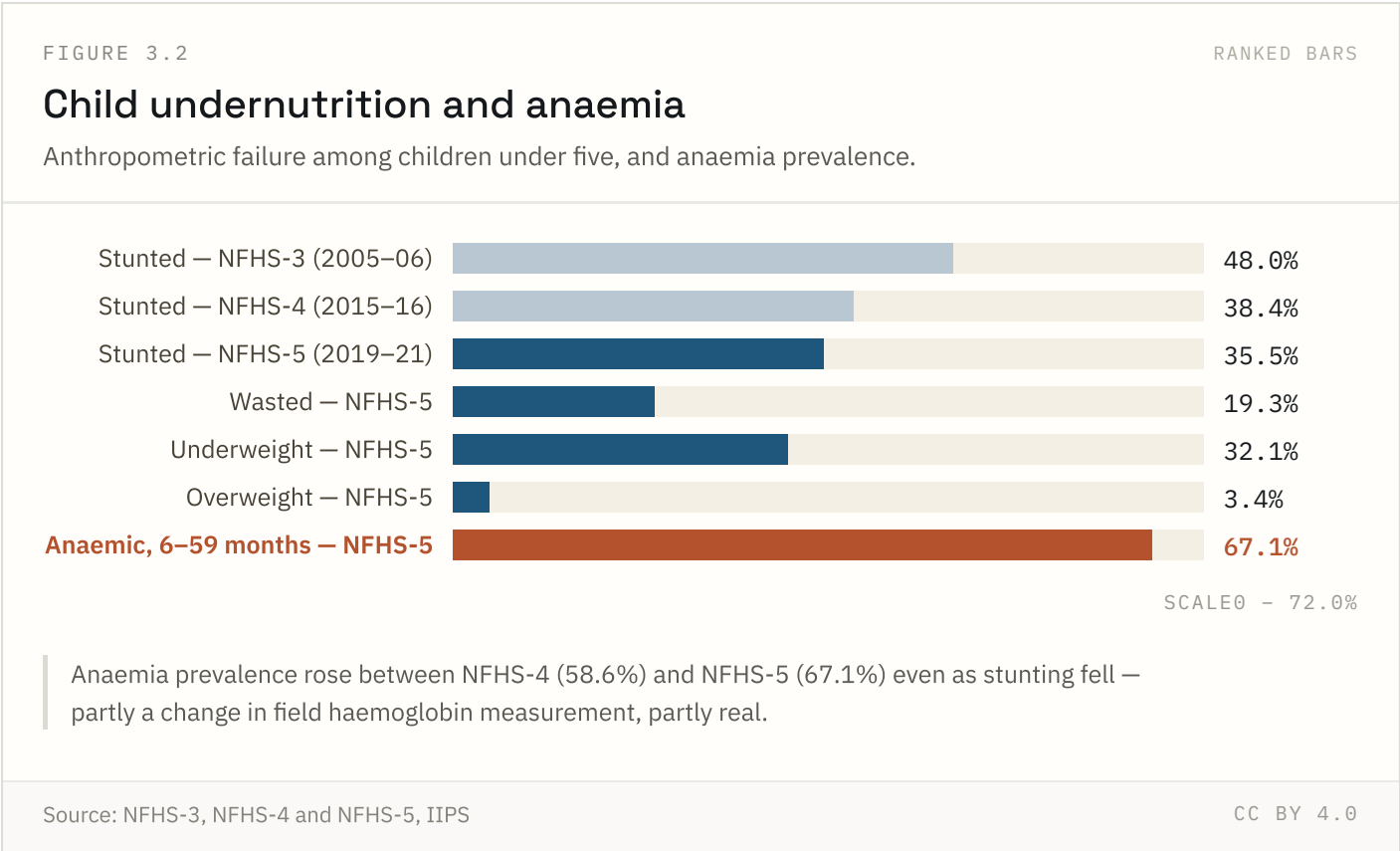
Health & nutrition

3 of 4 indicators in this chapter carry state-level detail; the rest are published at national level only.

FIGURE 3.1 NATIONAL + STATE

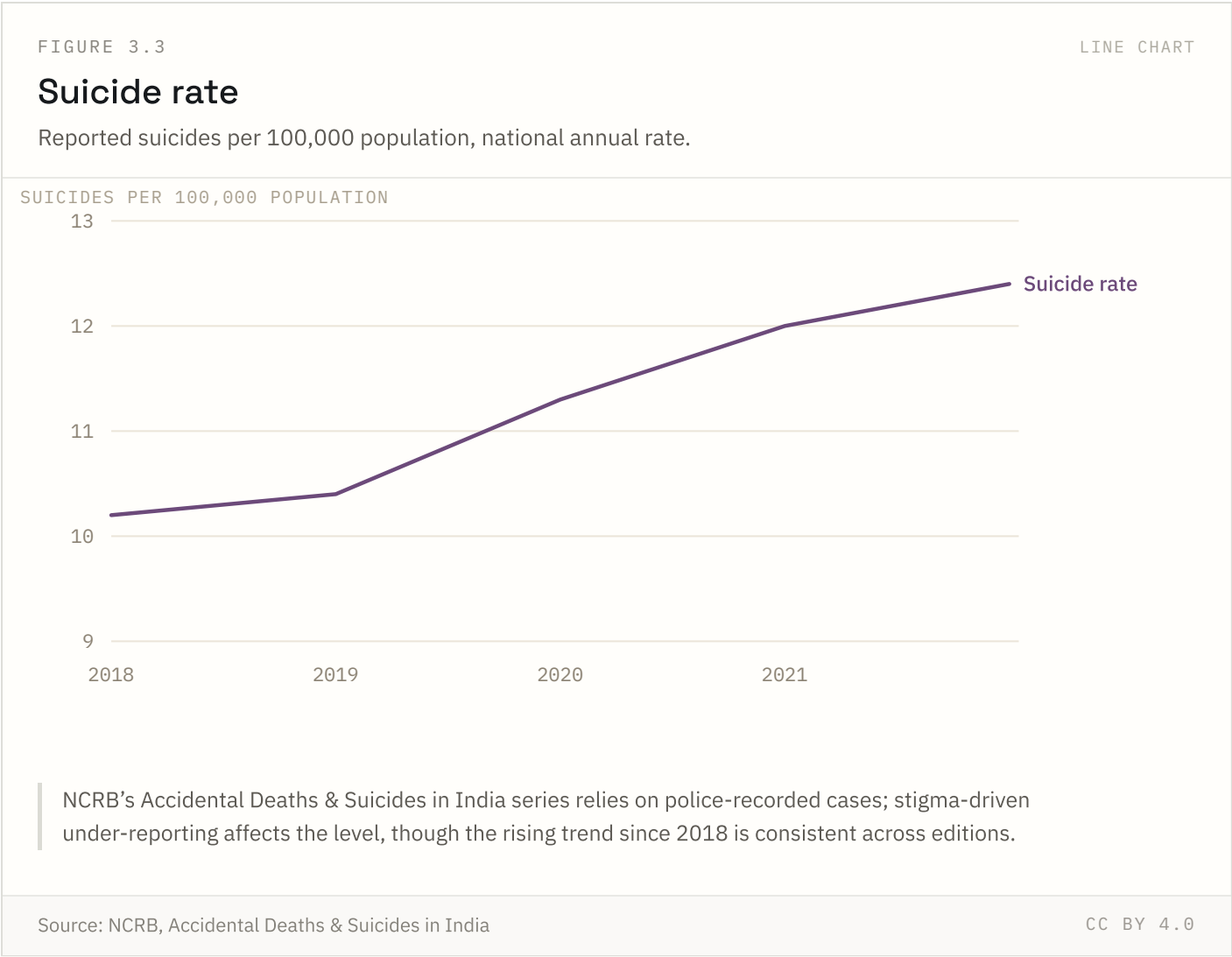


India accounted for roughly a fifth of global under-five deaths in 2022, down from a third in 1990. The decline is steepest in states that expanded institutional delivery fastest after 2005.



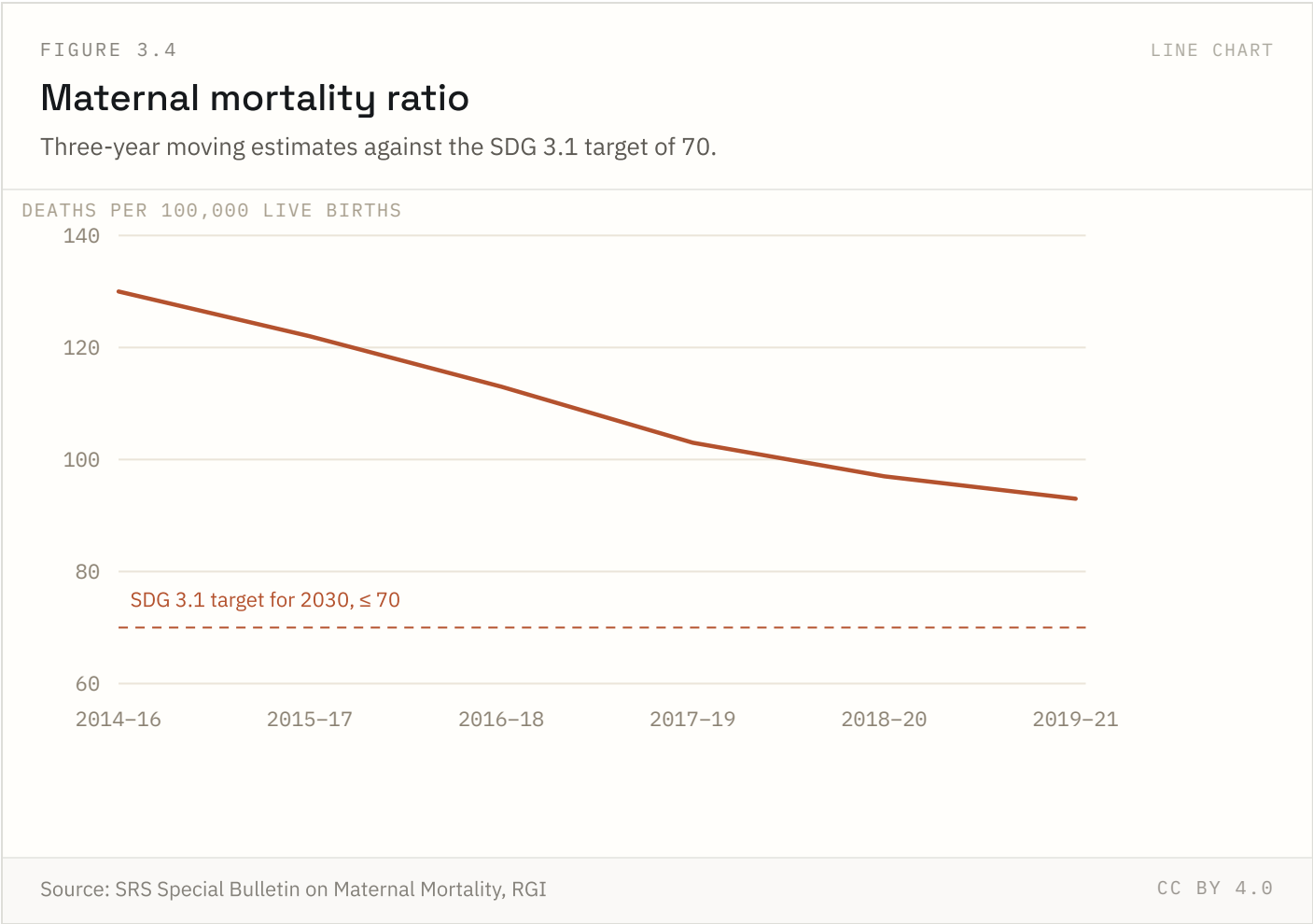
Stunting (low height-for-age) reflects chronic undernutrition; wasting (low weight-for-height) reflects acute deficits. Anaemia prevalence rose between NFHS-4 and NFHS-5 even as stunting fell — partly a measurement change, partly real.

FIGURE 3.3 NATIONAL ONLY



The rate has risen every year since 2018. NCRB figures are police-recorded cases; stigma and, until 2017, the criminal status of attempted suicide are known sources of under-reporting, so levels are likely understated even where the trend is real.

Source: NCRB, Accidental Deaths & Suicides in India Coverage: 2018–2022 Updated: 18 Aug 2026



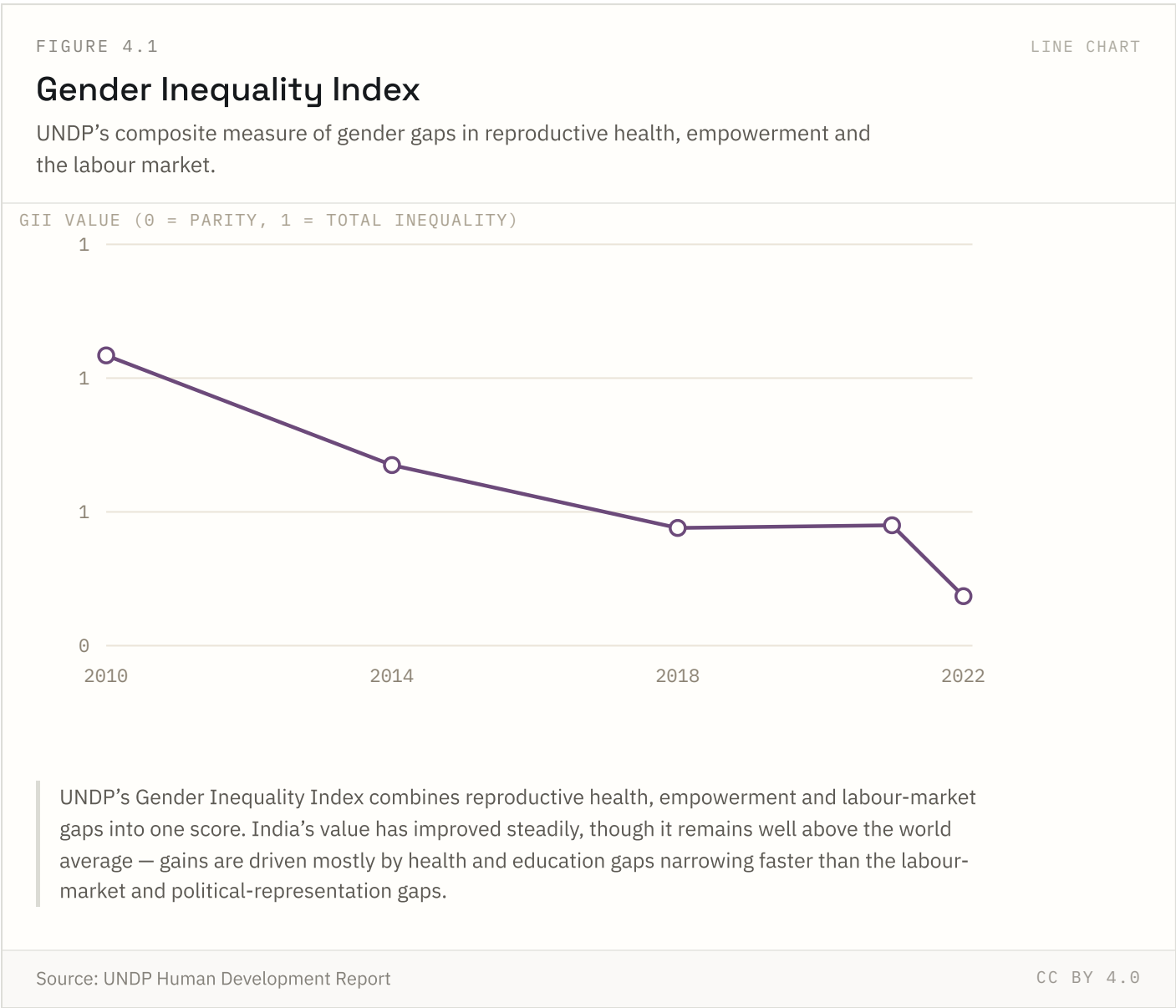
MMR fell from 130 in 2014–16 to 93 in 2019–21. Eight States have already met the SDG target; Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Bihar remain furthest from it.

Source: SRS Special Bulletin on Maternal Mortality, RGI Coverage: 2014–16 to 2019–21 Updated: 02 Jun 2026

Human development & wellbeing

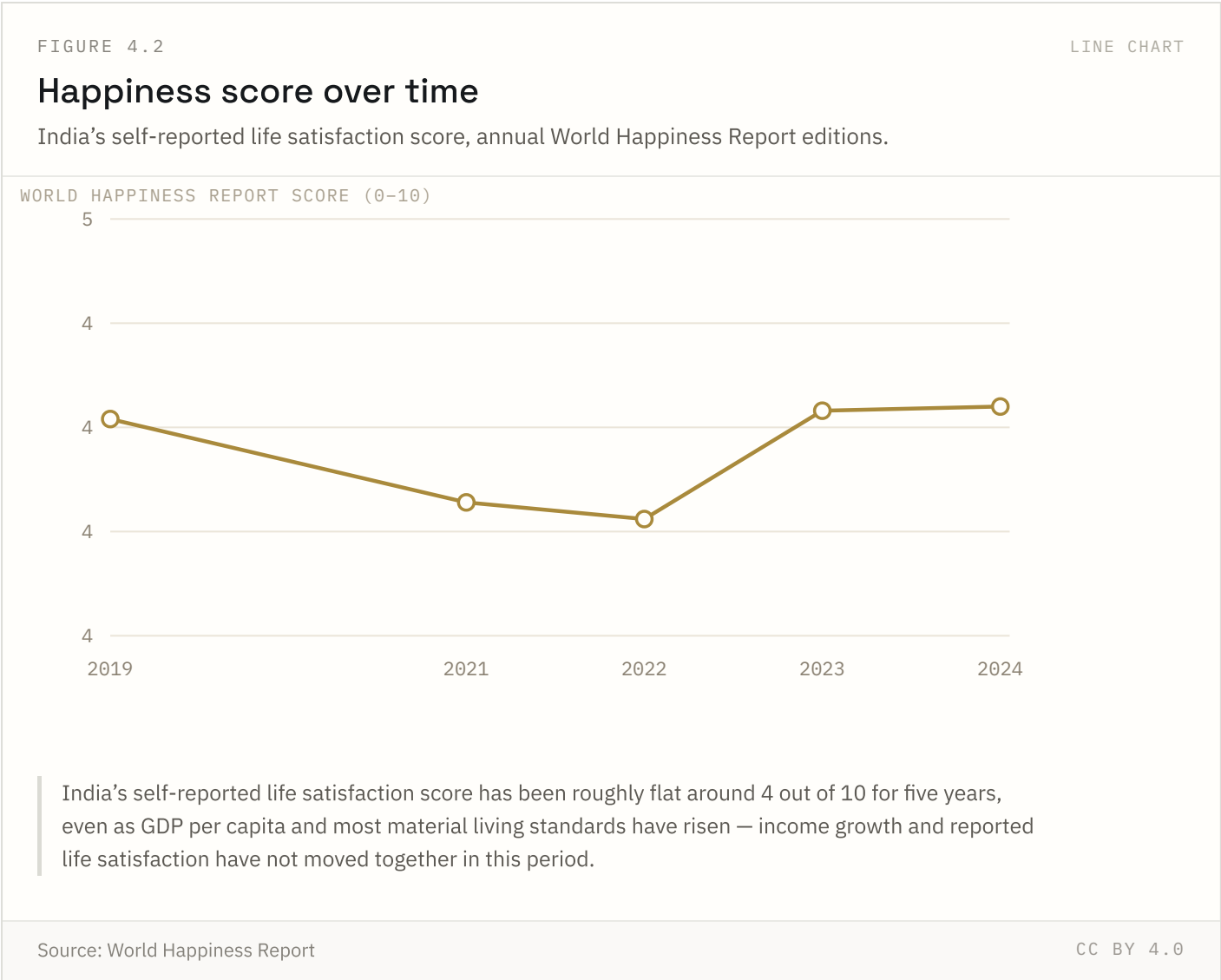
All 4 indicators in this chapter are published at national level only. No state breakdown is available from the sources used.

FIGURE 4.1 NATIONAL ONLY



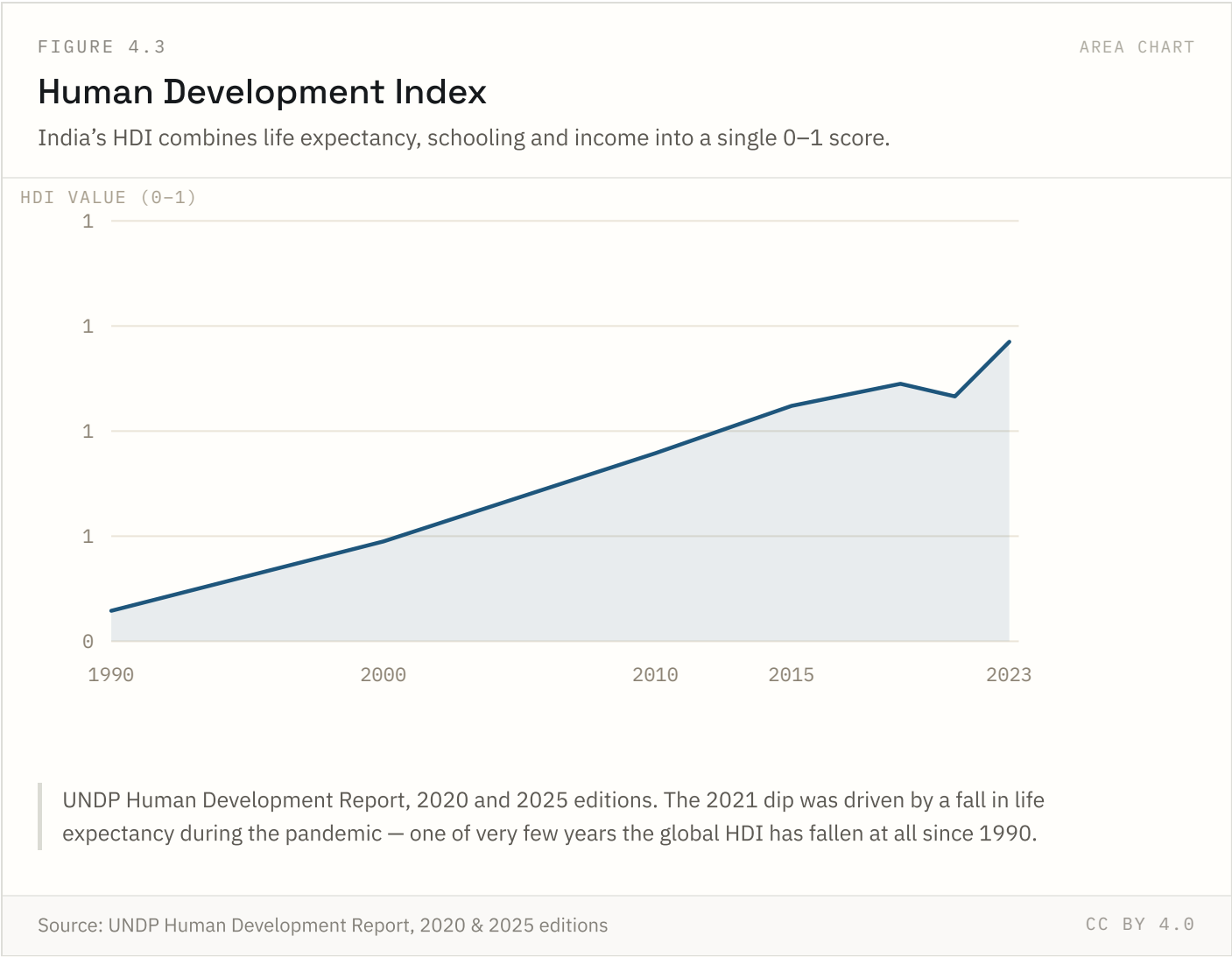
India's GII has improved steadily, mostly on faster progress in health and education than in labour-market participation and political representation — the index blends these into one score, so it can mask which underlying gap is moving and which is stuck.

FIGURE 4.2 NATIONAL ONLY

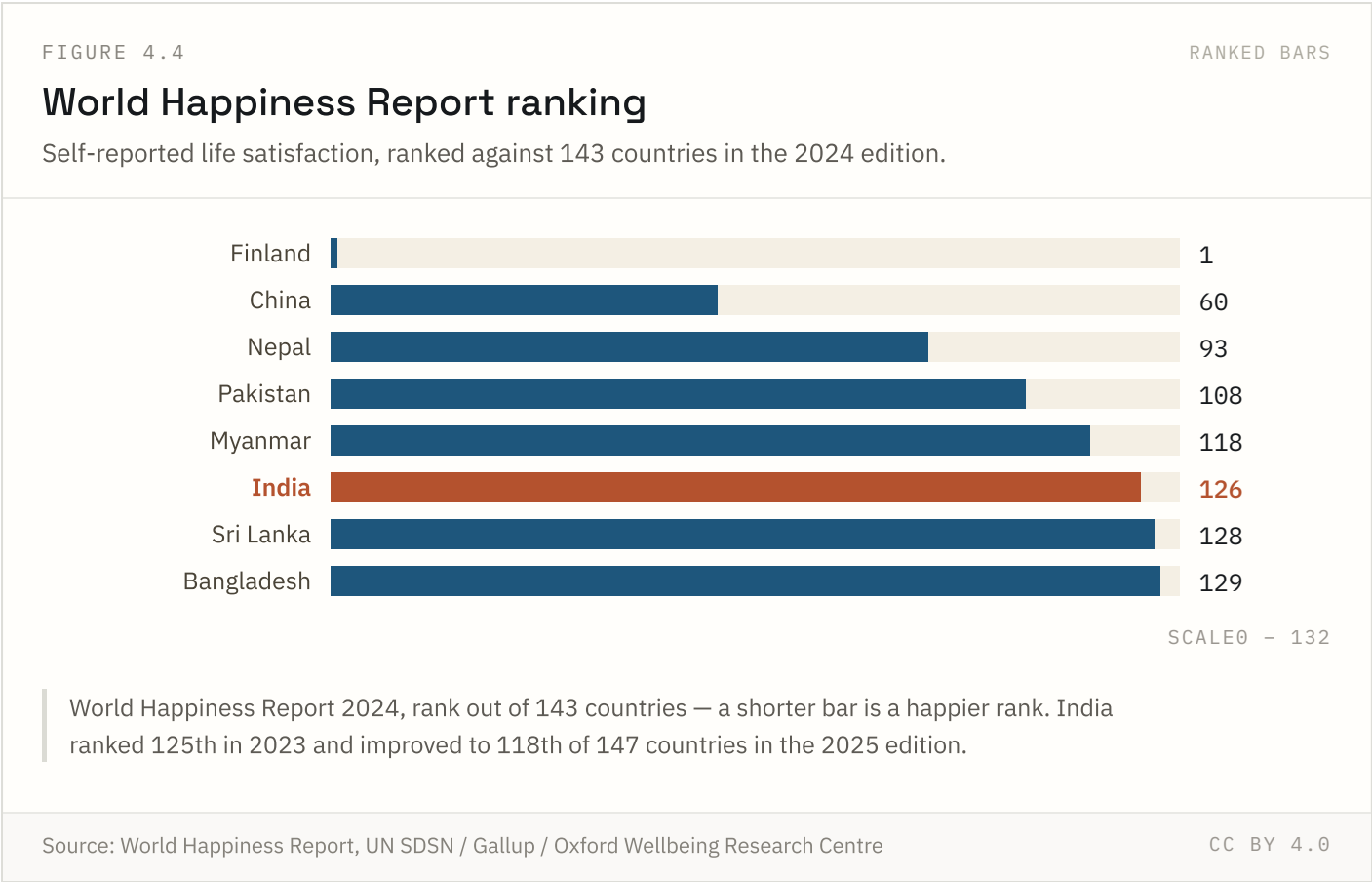


The score has stayed close to 4 out of 10 for five years even as GDP per capita and most material indicators in this dataset have risen — a reminder that self-reported wellbeing and income growth do not move in lockstep.

FIGURE 4.3 NATIONAL ONLY



India's HDI rose from 0.429 in 1990 to 0.645 in 2019, then fell for two straight years as life expectancy dropped during the pandemic — one of very few declines the global HDI has recorded since 1990. It recovered to 0.685 in 2023, ranking India 130th of 193 countries, still in the medium human-development band, just below the 0.700 threshold for 'high'.



India ranked 126th of 143 countries in 2024, behind China by 66 places and behind every neighbour shown except Bangladesh and Sri Lanka. The ranking is built from self-reported life satisfaction (the Cantril ladder) alongside GDP per capita, social support, healthy life expectancy, freedom, generosity and corruption perception — it measures reported wellbeing, not an objective standard of living. India improved to 118th of 147 countries in the 2025 edition.

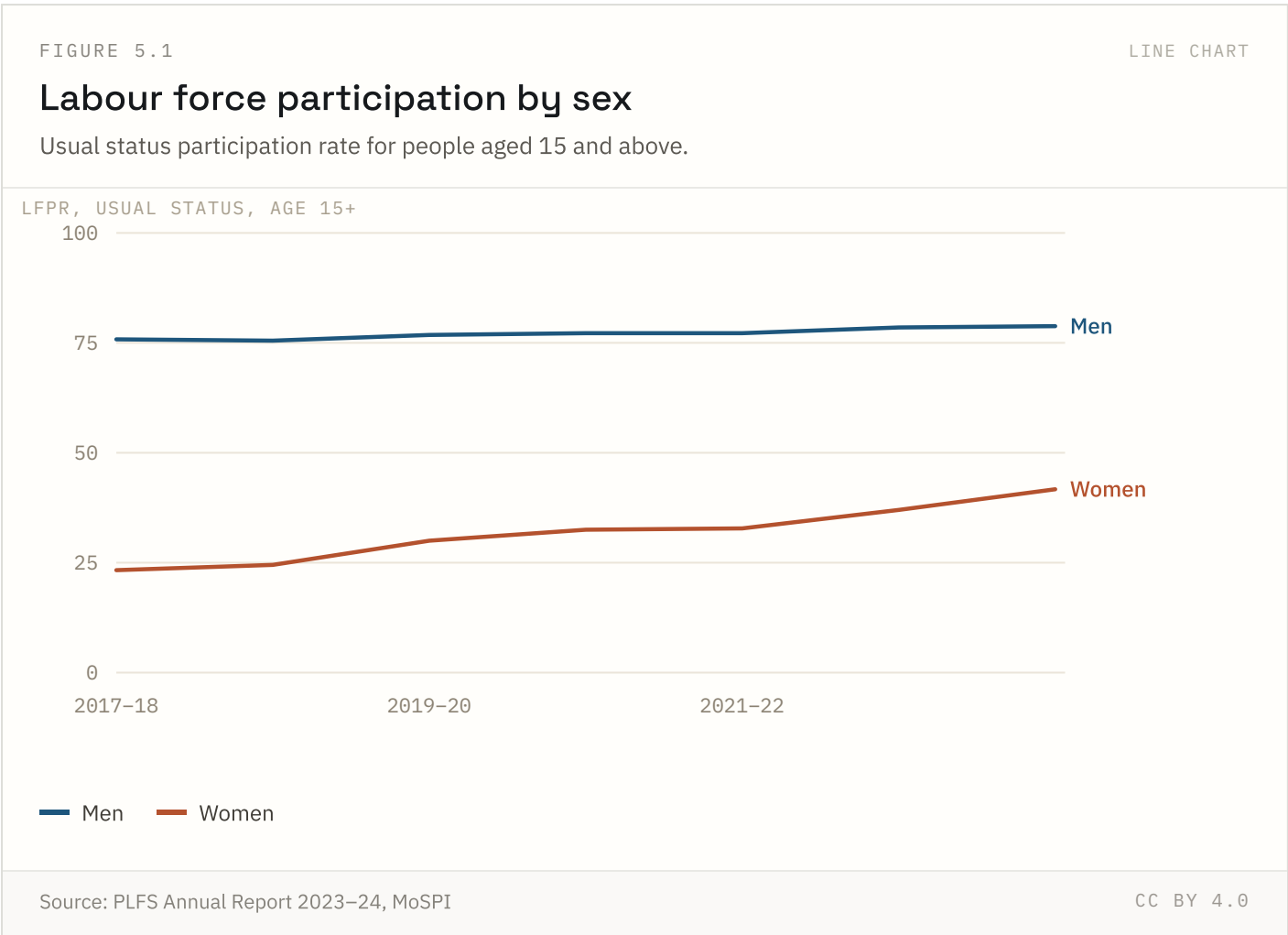
Source: World Happiness Report, UN SDSN / Gallup / Oxford Wellbeing Research Centre Coverage: 2024

Updated: 17 Aug 2026

Employment & labour

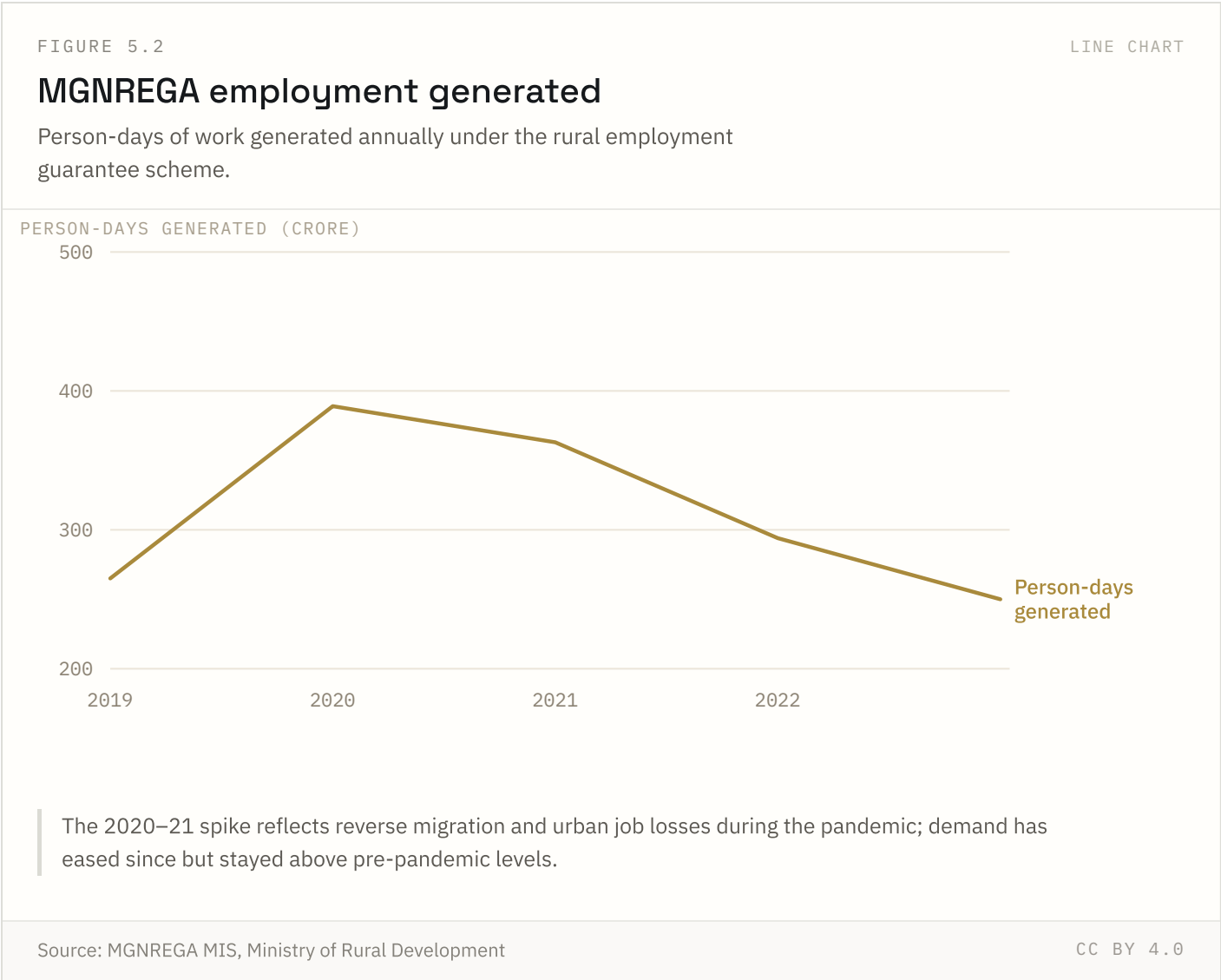
2 of 3 indicators in this chapter carry state-level detail; the rest are published at national level only.

FIGURE 5.1 NATIONAL + STATE

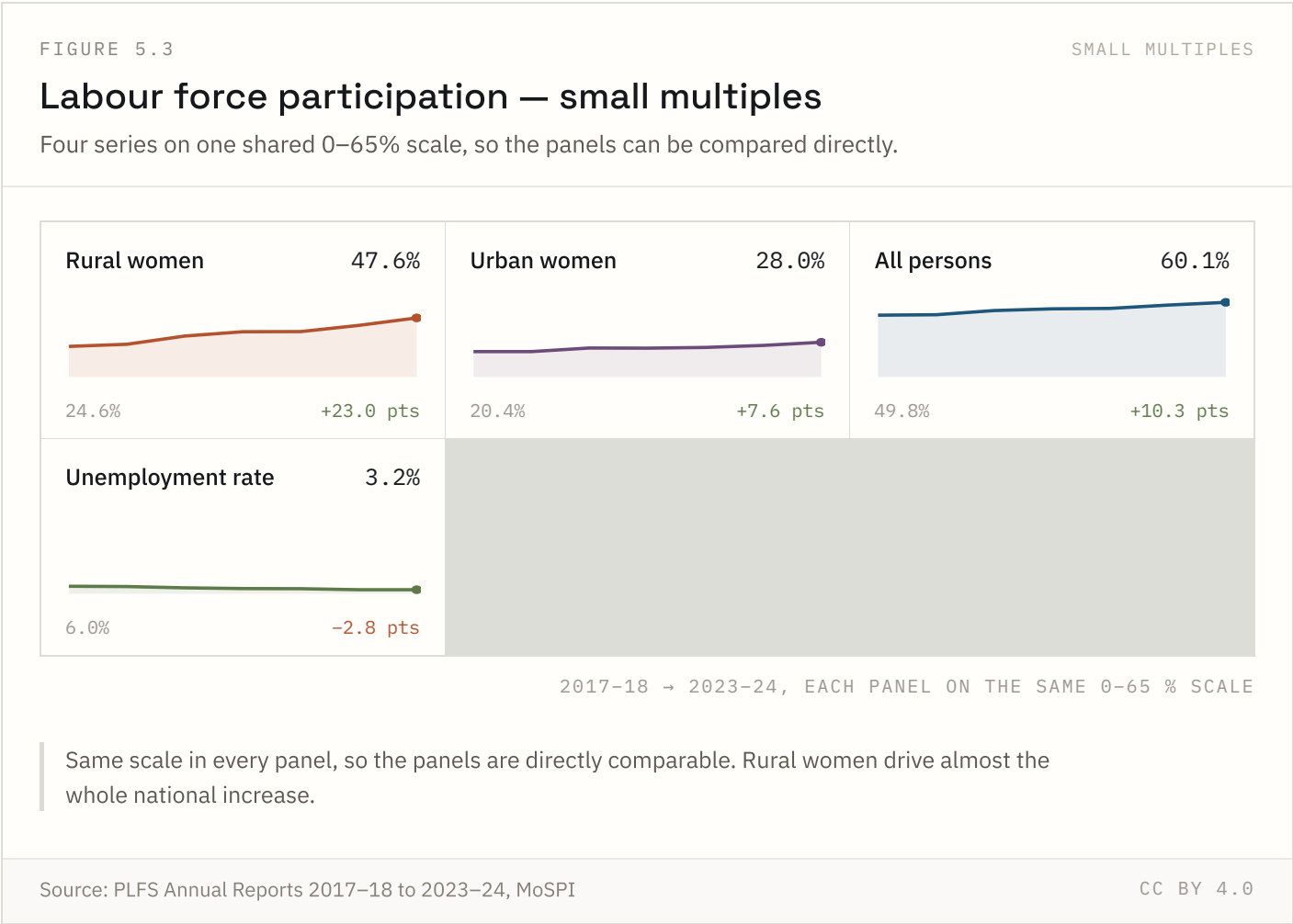


Female participation has risen sharply since 2018 on the PLFS usual-status definition, but most of the increase is in unpaid work on family farms and enterprises. Salaried employment for women has grown far more slowly.

FIGURE 5.2 NATIONAL ONLY



The scheme acts as an automatic stabiliser: person-days jumped 47% in 2020–21 as migrant workers returned to villages during the pandemic, then eased as urban labour markets recovered.



Rural women account for almost the entire national increase: their LFPR nearly doubled from 24.6% to 47.6%, while urban women moved from 20.4% to 28.0%. Part of the change is measurement — PLFS probes unpaid work in family enterprises more carefully than the surveys it replaced.

Source: PLFS Annual Reports 2017-18 to 2023-24, MoSPI Coverage: 2017-18 to 2023-24 Updated: 21 Jul 2026

Methodology and limitations

Every figure in this report is reproduced from a published source without adjustment. India Insight Lab does not estimate, model or interpolate the values shown. Each chart carries the source it came from, the years it covers and the date the series was last updated.

Three limitations apply to everything above, and are stated rather than worked around:

- Geographic depth.** Indicators reach national and, for 11 of 25 series, state level. District and city figures are not included because comparable data is not yet integrated.

- **Comparability across sources.** Series drawn from different sources use different definitions, reference periods and sampling designs. They are shown side by side but are not adjusted onto a common basis.
- **Currency.** Update dates vary by series; the most recent revision date is shown beneath each figure. Some official series lag by several years.

Nothing in this report is projected. Where a series ends, the report ends with it. No forecast, scenario or extrapolation has been added to extend a trend beyond its published data.

References

21 sources used in this report.

1	Census of India 2011
2	Census of India 2011; SRS 2021, RGI
3	Census of India, D-series migration tables
4	Census of India, decennial rounds
5	Census of India; UN World Population Prospects
6	Census of India; UN World Urbanization Prospects
7	Election Commission of India; Ministry of Panchayati Raj
8	MGNREGA MIS, Ministry of Rural Development
9	NCRB, Accidental Deaths & Suicides in India
10	NFHS-3, NFHS-4 and NFHS-5, IIPS
11	National Population Projections 2011–2036, Registrar General of India
12	PLFS Annual Report 2023–24, MoSPI
13	PLFS Annual Report, MoSPI
14	PLFS Annual Reports 2017–18 to 2023–24, MoSPI
15	SRS Abridged Life Tables 2017–21, RGI
16	SRS Special Bulletin on Maternal Mortality, RGI

17	SRS Statistical Report 2021, RGI
18	UNDP Human Development Report
19	UNDP Human Development Report, 2020 & 2025 editions
20	World Happiness Report
21	World Happiness Report, UN SDSN / Gallup / Oxford Wellbeing Research Centre

Source URLs, licence terms and retrieval dates are not yet recorded for every series. Adding them is scheduled work, and until it is done these references name the publication rather than link to it.